

POLITICAL PRAGMATISM IN PAKISTAN

A Governance Roadmap Centered on Public Interest, Institutional Balance, Economic Self-Reliance, and Systemic Realism

COMPREHENSIVE POLICY TREATISE | STATE GOVERNANCE & STRATEGIC POLICY FRAMEWORK

A treatise on restructuring national institutions, eradicating corruption, modernizing governance, and prioritizing the sovereign welfare of the citizens of Pakistan.

AUTHORED BY

Gohar Nawaz Sandhu

Advocate Supreme Court of Pakistan | Political Scholar

PREAMBLE

"Whereas prima-facie Pakistan is a sovereign country and the people of Pakistan are the sole reason for the existence of the State of Pakistan, the prime motive of any system, constitution, laws, and state policies must revolve around the direct interest, benefit, and welfare of the people of Pakistan as the absolute top priority based on Pragmatism. We must adopt a realistic and objective approach tailored to public requirements, fundamental needs, constitutional rights, national prosperity, culture, social behavior, national defense, security threats, economic sustainability, trade balances, foreign policy, education, healthcare, agriculture, employment, justice, social equity, judicial independence, and uncompromising institutional transparency."

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1. Introduction of Political Pragmatics in Pakistan

Every sovereign nation operates within its own unique crucible of domestic dynamics, geopolitical realities, historical developments, cultural imperatives, trade conditions, and socio-religious frameworks. Consequently, imported ideologies—whether rigid classical capitalism, state socialism, or orthodox communism—cannot be dogmatically transposed onto Pakistan's complex political landscape. These theoretical models fail to address the lived realities and institutional friction points of the Pakistani state.

The only governance paradigm capable of guiding Pakistan onto a sustainable, progressive path is **Political Pragmatism**. Pragmatism discards theoretical inflexibility in favor of practical, realistic problem-solving calibrated to the exact challenges and fundamental needs of the country. This framework is governed by one non-negotiable core axiom: the primary interest, prosperity, and welfare of the people of Pakistan must take precedence over all else, without compromise or failure.

THE CORE AXIOM OF POLITICAL PRAGMATISM

Political decisions, legislative enactments, judicial rulings, and economic policies must be evaluated strictly by their tangible utility and positive impact on the lives of ordinary Pakistani citizens, rather than by alignment with abstract dogmas or elite interests.

Historically, Pakistan's statecraft has suffered from a pervasive disconnect between state power and public welfare. Power centers have repeatedly prioritized personal enrichment, dynastic consolidation, institutional aggrandizement, and external patron interests over the fundamental rights of the populace. Political Pragmatism seeks to dismantle this self-serving apparatus and replace it with an objective, outcome-driven system of state management.

2. Institutional Restructuring & Civil-Military Synergy

While classical governance models advocate a strict theoretical Separation of Powers, absolute institutional isolation is neither realistic nor effective in Pakistan's security environment. Pakistan has faced existential external security challenges since its inception, necessitating a highly capable defense apparatus.

Addressing Security Realities & Geopolitical Threats

The Armed Forces of Pakistan operate under continuous operational readiness due to persistent offensive postures from neighboring adversaries—most notably the ideological doctrine of Akhand Bharat (Greater India), which poses a direct threat to Pakistan's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Furthermore, regional instability resulting from conflicts involving global powers, Israel, Iran, and the broader Middle East has intensified Pakistan's national defense obligations.

Civil-Military Coordination Framework

To navigate these complex internal and external security challenges, close structural coordination between civilian and military leadership is imperative. However, to prevent friction, political manipulation, and institutional destabilization, clear statutory boundaries must be established.

Pragmatic Mechanism for Defense Leadership Appointments:

To eliminate political bargaining and institutional friction surrounding the appointment of the Chief of Defense Forces / Army Chief, the relevant statutes should be amended to implement one of two objective mechanisms:

- 1. **Strict Seniority Principle:** The command automatically devolves upon the senior-most officer of the Armed Forces upon the retirement of the incumbent, mirroring seamless succession models in professional judicial systems.
- 2. **Corps Commanders' Voting Collegium:** Alternatively, the appointment is made from among the top three senior-most Generals through a majority vote conducted within a formal Corps Commanders' Conference.

3. Judicial Independence, Appointments & Legal Reforms

An independent, impartial, and highly competent judiciary is the foundational requirement for social justice and public confidence in the state. Judicial independence in Pakistan has frequently been compromised by political interference, executive pressure, and procedural inefficiencies.

Appointment and Tenure Reforms

To secure the independence of the judiciary, judicial appointments and promotions must be insulated from political patronage. There should remain a single Supreme Court of Pakistan, headed by the Chief Justice of Pakistan (CJP).

Judicial Position	Pragmatic Selection Mechanism	Primary Governance Objective
Chief Justice of Pakistan	Automatic elevation based on strict seniority, OR selection from the 3 senior-most judges via majority vote of the Full Court.	Eliminates executive favoritism and partisan lobbying.
High Court Chief Justices	Elevation of senior-most judge, OR selection from top 3 candidates by Full Bench of the respective High Court.	Ensures provincial judicial leadership is grounded in merit and peer respect.
Subordinate Judiciary	Induction strictly through rigorous public competitive examinations, with career advancement based on transparent seniority and performance metrics.	Standardizes legal competence and eliminates local nepotism.

Jurisdictional Boundaries & Substantive Justice

While the judiciary must remain robust in protecting fundamental rights, it must respect the constitutional boundary separating judicial oversight from executive governance. The judiciary should not possess arbitrary authority to de-seat elected high officials such as the Prime Minister, President, or Chief of Armed Forces outside of precise, strict constitutional impeachment processes.

Furthermore, courts must transition from dismissing cases on technicalities or minor procedural flaws toward resolving disputes on substantive merit. The primary duty of the judiciary is the effective redressal of public grievances, making legal procedural simplification and e-court integration paramount.

4. Executive Service Meritocracy & Legislative Integrity

A functional executive branch requires a professional civil service operating free from political influence, while a credible legislative branch demands genuine public representation.

Executive Branch Overhaul: All appointments within executive departments, civil services, and autonomous statutory bodies must be conducted strictly through competitive, merit-based examinations administered by public service commissions. Career

progression, promotions, and postings must be governed by transparent seniority and objective performance evaluation standards to eliminate favoritism, corruption, and political patronage.

Legislative Mandate & Public Welfare: Parliament serves as the primary instrument of popular sovereignty. The core responsibility of elected legislators is to enact laws that advance public welfare, guarantee social justice, and build national infrastructure. Parliament must prioritize legislation establishing universal healthcare insurance, standardized public education, agricultural insurance schemes, and citizen safety.

5. Electoral Reform & Independent Election Commission

Free, fair, and transparent elections are the non-negotiable prerequisite for political stability. When electoral integrity is compromised, the democratic social contract collapses, leading to civil unrest, institutional distrust, and national instability.

Reforming the Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP):

- **Judicial Oversight:** The ECP must operate under the administrative supervision of the Chief Justice of Pakistan during electoral cycles to ensure total independence from executive influence.
- **Biometric Verification:** Universal implementation of biometric voter verification systems at all polling stations, replicating successful models used in bar association and corporate elections to eliminate ghost voting and ballot manipulation.
- **Electoral Accountability:** Strict legal penalties and immediate disqualification for any electoral official or candidate found complicit in election rigging.

6. Eradication of Systemic Corruption & Financial Oversight

Systemic corruption is an existential threat to Pakistan's economic survival and social cohesion. Anti-graft agencies themselves have frequently fallen victim to corruption and selective political targeting.

Zero-Tolerance Policy & Anti-Corruption Overhaul: The state must enforce an uncompromising zero-tolerance policy against corruption across all public institutions. Primary focus must be placed on cleansing the primary accountability bodies:

- **Accountability Agencies:** Reforming the National Accountability Bureau (NAB), Federal Investigation Agency (FIA), and Provincial Anti-Corruption Establishments to ensure independent, non-partisan operations.
- **Revenue Generation Bodies:** Enforcing strict oversight within money-collecting bodies including the Federal Board of Revenue (FBR), Customs, and Boards of Revenue (BOR) where leakages undermine national revenue.
- **Law Enforcement & Judiciary:** Eradicating corruption in police departments and lower courts, where petty and systemic corruption directly harms citizens seeking justice.

7. Economic Sovereignty, Trade Balance & Debt Strategy

Pakistan's economic vulnerability stems from trade deficits, reliance on foreign currency reserves, heavy debt servicing, and structural policy misalignments.

Achieving Trade Balance & Self-Reliance: To stabilize the rupee and reduce dependency on foreign currencies such as the US Dollar, Pakistan must implement import-substitution strategies and expand export capacity:

- **Energy Subsidies Reduction via Regional Trade:** Preferentially import natural resources from neighboring partners—such as oil from Iran and natural gas from Azerbaijan—to lower import bills and freight costs.
- **Domestic Resource Exploitation:** Accelerate domestic exploration of oil, gas, and mineral wealth to minimize foreign energy dependency.

- **Export Promotion:** Facilitate export-oriented agriculture, value-added industrial production, and international tourism to generate steady foreign exchange inflows.

PRAGMATIC DEBT MANAGEMENT STRATEGY

Pakistan must break the cycle of perpetual reliance on International Monetary Fund (IMF) bailouts. The state should adopt a dual policy:

1. **Immediate Ceiling on New Foreign Loans:** Cease non-essential foreign borrowing, replacing deficit spending with strict fiscal discipline and elite austerity.
2. **Structured Repayment Realism:** Negotiate structured debt re-profiling and prioritize debt repayment strictly within generated domestic surpluses without compromising essential public survival needs.

8. Grassroots Local Governance & Union Council Empowerment

Local government is the fundamental organ of state administration closest to the everyday life of citizens. Top-heavy governance models that centralize power in provincial capitals fail to deliver basic services.

Structure & Functions of Local Government: Local government institutions must be empowered to solve citizen problems directly at their doorstep:

- **Grassroots Infrastructure:** Management of basic municipal development, primary schools, basic health units (BHUs), and local sanitation.
- **Dispute Resolution Committees:** Establishing Arbitration Councils and Small Cause Courts at the Union Council level to settle civil and minor criminal disputes locally, bypassing costly litigation.
- **Fiscal Autonomy:** Empowering local councils to collect designated local market taxes and municipal revenues to directly finance community development.
- **Constitutional Protection:** Mandating that local body elections occur concurrently with National and Provincial elections, with explicit constitutional prohibitions against federal or provincial dissolution of local councils.

9. Geopolitical Realism & Pragmatic Foreign Policy

Pakistan's foreign policy must be anchored in economic self-interest, regional stability, and strategic balance rather than ideological commitments.

Regional Integration & The Asian Century: With the global balance of economic and political power shifting toward Asia, Pakistan's geographic position at the crossroads of South Asia, Central Asia, and the Middle East offers strategic advantages:

- **Strategic Partnerships:** Deepening economic and infrastructure integration with China (CPEC) while maintaining strong diplomatic and economic ties with Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Central Asian states.
- **Balanced Power Diplomacy:** Expanding trade, energy, and security engagement with Russia and regional neighbors while maintaining constructive relations with Western economies.
- **Diplomatic Mediation:** Playing an active diplomatic role in regional conflict resolution such as mediating between the United States and Iran to foster peace and commercial connectivity.

10. The Comprehensive Welfare State & Public Rights

The primary purpose of the state is to serve as a welfare vehicle securing life, liberty, dignity, and economic opportunity for all citizens.

Fundamental Rights & Designated Public Demonstration Zones: While constitutional rights—including freedom of speech, assembly, movement, and trade—are guaranteed, they must be exercised responsibly without infringing upon the rights of others.

Standardized Public Protest Infrastructure

To eliminate frequent blockades of major transport arteries and economic disruptions caused by political demonstrations, the state should designate dedicated, fully equipped protest venues in every major city (equipped with sanitation, clean water, and security). All political entities must utilize these designated spaces equally, keeping public highways and commercial centers open.

Essential Public Services & Quality Assurance: The Federal and Provincial governments must guarantee universal coverage in essential life needs through national insurance schemes and regulatory enforcement:

- **Universal Healthcare & Education:** State-backed health insurance and quality public education for every citizen.
- **Eradication of Adulteration:** Zero-tolerance enforcement against the contamination and adulteration of food products, medicines, agricultural inputs, and construction materials. Offender networks must face severe penal sentences.
- **Social Wellbeing:** State encouragement and facilitation of affordable marriages, youth sports, public health exercises, and tourism.

11. Environmental Resilience & Disaster Mitigation

Pakistan is exceptionally vulnerable to climate-induced environmental disasters, particularly recurrent catastrophic flooding that destabilizes rural communities and damages national infrastructure.

Permanent Flood Mitigation Strategy: Emergency relief operations must be replaced by long-term structural resilience engineering:

- **Water Infrastructure:** Rapid construction of small and medium dams, water storage reservoirs, and standardized drainage bypass channels.
- **Infrastructure Maintenance:** Regular desilting and clearing of natural water channels, canals, and urban storm drainage systems.
- **Afforestation & Climate Adaptation:** Mass afforestation initiatives to stabilize soil along river basins and vulnerable northern slopes.
- **All-Weather Northern Corridor Connectivity:** Landslide protection and winter maintenance along northern road networks to sustain trade and tourism year-round.

12. Provincial Autonomy & Federal Cohesion

A stable federation balances provincial self-governance with a strong, effective central government.

Federal Domain (Centralized Cohesion)	Provincial Domain (Administrative Autonomy)
National Defense & Foreign Policy	Local Civil Administration & Policing Execution
Currency, Monetary Policy & National Revenue Framework	Provincial Economic Execution & Regional Trade Facilitation
National Security, Federal Law & Order Standards	Intra-Provincial Transport & Infrastructure Development

Federal Domain (Centralized Cohesion)	Provincial Domain (Administrative Autonomy)
National Health Insurance & Education Benchmarks	Delivery of Provincial Schooling & Hospital Management

13. Structural Protection & Empowerment of Women

Women constitute over half of Pakistan's population. True national progress is unattainable if women are excluded from full, safe participation in economic, social, and civic life.

Establishing Harassment-Free Dedicated Institutions: To guarantee complete physical security, dignity, and cultural comfort, the state should progressively establish dedicated, female-administered public environments:

Systemic Gender Segregation & Protection Model

- **Education & Healthcare:** Expanding fully equipped, women-administered primary, secondary, and tertiary educational institutions and specialized women's hospitals.
- **Law Enforcement & Judiciary:** Expanding dedicated Women Police Stations, specialized female security units, and female-led courts presided over by female judges to handle gender-sensitive cases.
- **Safe Transit & Workplace Environment:** Providing secure, dedicated public transportation networks and enforced workplace anti-harassment mechanisms.

Outcome: *Eliminating safety concerns enables millions of qualified women to enter the workforce as teachers, doctors, lawyers, administrators, police officers, and entrepreneurs, boosting economic productivity.*

14. Energy Crisis Management & Overhauling IPP Agreements

Exorbitant energy tariffs, recurring load shedding, and structural power sector deficits represent a major drag on Pakistan's economy, closing industrial units and fueling inflation.

Resolving the Independent Power Producers (IPPs) Dilemma: A primary driver of high electricity costs is unfair contract structures with Independent Power Producers (IPPs), many of which are linked to elite interests.

KEY IPP CONTRACT REFORM POLICY

The state must immediately review and renegotiate sovereign IPP agreements to eliminate onerous "Capacity Payment" clauses under which the public pays billions for unproduced or unconsumed electricity. Payments must be restructured strictly on an "Electricity Produced and Delivered" model. Contracts failing renegotiation in the public interest must be terminated.

Energy Mix Diversification: Shift the national energy grid away from expensive imported fossil fuels toward domestic hydel, solar, wind, and civil nuclear sources, alongside direct pipeline imports from neighboring states.

15. National Security, Counter-Terrorism & Deprivation Relief

Sustained economic growth requires absolute internal security and the total eradication of terrorism.

Combating Extremism & Enemy Exploitation: Adversarial foreign intelligence entities actively exploit domestic security gaps and socio-economic grievances to foster insurgency, particularly in border regions such as Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

Dual-Track Counter-Terrorism Strategy

1. **Uncompromising Kinetic Action:** Continuous intelligence-led security operations to eliminate terrorist networks and secure national borders.
2. **Addressing Socio-Economic Deprivation:** Massive state investment in education, healthcare, clean water, infrastructure, and job creation in affected regions to remove the root causes of alienation exploited by hostile actors.

16. Overcoming Political Polarization through Tolerance

Extreme political polarization has degraded democratic discourse, weakened governance, discouraged investment, and invited institutional instability.

Fostering Political Co-existence: Political rivalries must be bounded by national interest. Political parties must establish cross-party consensus on core structural areas: national defense, foreign policy, free elections, judicial independence, and long-term economic strategy. Political entities must abandon calls for extra-constitutional interventions, recommitting to non-violent, principled political competition.

17. Digital Census & Data-Driven National Planning

Effective public policy requires precise, unassailable demographic and socio-economic data.

Modernizing Demographic Audits: National census operations must utilize transparent digital verification methodologies to capture accurate metrics on population density, employment, migration patterns, income distribution, and utility demands. Accurate digital data ensures equitable resource distribution through the National Finance Commission (NFC) award and enables targeted infrastructure planning.

18. Political Party Reforms & New Democratic Leadership

Political parties are the primary training grounds for national leadership. Intra-party nepotism and dynastic control undermine democratic responsiveness.

Internal Party Democracy & Meritocratic Leadership:

- **Cadre Voting Rights:** Intra-party elections must be decided by dedicated, ideological party workers with established service records, preventing overnight takeovers by wealthy elites.
- **Broad-Based Representation:** Mandatory party ticket allocation for qualified candidates drawn from diverse socio-economic backgrounds—peasants, industrial workers, youth, women, lawyers, engineers, doctors, and minority groups.
- **Public Party Campaign Funding:** Establishing state-managed party funds to subsidize campaign expenses for meritorious, non-wealthy candidates, leveling the electoral playing field.

19. Austerity, Privatization & Eradicating Elite Privilege

The state exchequer cannot continue funding luxurious lifestyles, protocols, and perks for the political and bureaucratic elite while public services suffer from underfunding.

Austerity Enactments: A mandatory austerity policy must be enforced across all state branches:

- **Elimination of Free Utilities:** Immediate revocation of free electricity, gas, fuel, and housing allowances provided to politicians, judges, military officers, and civil bureaucrats. All public officials must pay market rates from their salaries.

- **Protocol Culture Dismantling:** Banning multi-vehicle motorcades, luxury official SUVs, and VIP travel protocols that disrupt public traffic and waste state funds.
- **Privatization of Loss-Making State-Owned Enterprises (SOEs):** Chronic loss-making entities that drain the exchequer must be privatized through transparent, competitive public auctions. Profit-making strategic assets should be retained and professionalized under private-sector management standards.

20. Modernizing Agriculture & Rural Economy

Agriculture is the backbone of Pakistan's economy, supporting food security and employment. However, outdated practices and market exploitation continue to depress yields and farmer incomes.

Agricultural Reform Blueprint:

- **Eliminating Exploitative Middlemen:** Establishing direct digital farm-to-market trading platforms and state-monitored procurement centers to secure fair pricing for farmers.
- **Input Quality Assurance:** Enforcing strict penal sanctions against uncertified, adulterated seeds, fertilizers, and pesticides.
- **Crop Insurance & Credit Support:** Providing state-backed crop and livestock insurance against climate damage, alongside interest-free micro-credit for modern farming equipment and efficient drip-irrigation systems.

21. Development of Small Cities & Balanced Regional Growth

Uncontrolled rural-to-urban migration toward megacities like Karachi, Lahore, and Islamabad creates severe urban strain while underutilizing regional talent and land.

Regional Economic Urbanization: To achieve balanced regional development, the state must build modern civic infrastructure in secondary and tertiary towns (Tehsils and District headquarters):

- Establishing high-quality regional hospitals, technical universities, and modern commercial hubs in smaller cities.
- Empowering local municipal governments to manage regional development using locally retained tax revenues.
- Creating local economic opportunities to allow citizens to thrive in their home districts without needing to migrate to overcrowded megacities.

22. Protection of Minority Rights & Equal Citizenship

The moral test of any civil society lies in its treatment of minority communities.

CONSTITUTIONAL EQUALITY & NON-DISCRIMINATION

All citizens of Pakistan—regardless of faith, caste, creed, or ethnicity—possess equal constitutional rights and protections. The state must guarantee complete freedom of worship, rigorous security for places of worship and property, and zero tolerance for forced conversions, extrajudicial persecution, or discrimination in public appointments.

*** END OF TREATISE ***